

- It's probably become a little bit more difficult for you to inherently feel motivated to jump in and read because some of these minor prophets are kind of hard to understand and it feels so removed from our day, and some of the themes get repeated so often that you're saying to yourself that if I've read one of these books I've read all of them.
- Breakdown some skills that might be useful to some of you in how you approach scripture.
 - There's no one right way to read or interpret scripture
 - The interpretation and the declaring of doctrine that is the role of prophets
 - For us as members of the church and can get pretty discouraging.
 - You can feel kind of lost and not know how to make it a more meaningful experience.
 - I would compare it to a coach going into a practice with his or her team and saying:
 - You didn't do so well in the last game; you have got to do better.
 - You have got to score more points.
 - You have got to prevent the other team from scoring.
 - You have to do better, or you will not win.
 - And the team is sitting there thinking, okay, we know that...
 - The thing we're struggling with is how?
 - We're pretty good with the why? (it leads to God) and the what (study scriptures)

- Nahum = NHM = Sorrow, consolation
 - Ninevah - capital city of the Assyrian empire was the largest empire at the time
 - up to 20xs larger than Jerusalem at the same time
 - it is in what is now Iraq.
 - Assyrians were ruthless people, they wanted resources, so
 - they ruled by blood and horror,
 - conquered, killed, anything to extract resources
 - I don't think they had a lot of friends.
 - Groups of people decided to gather together - like the Babylonians
 - God, speaking through Nahum, essentially saying: here's what's going to happen to you:
 - You cause death and destruction for various people over various years.
 - You will now reap what you have sown.
 - The capital is destroyed in 612 BC and the Assyrians fled into northern Iraq/southern Turkey
 - Egyptians are really worried about the Babylonians, coalesced with the Assyrians and they decided to fight against the Babylonians.
 - Massive battle in Carchemish in 605 BC and the Babylonians defeated both armies.
 - The people in Judah were kind of stuck in the middle and also had had some difficult situation
 - they had a king named Josiah who had come to the throne,
 - very righteous, doing a religious reformation, getting people more involved with God,
 - and then he died trying to stop the Egyptians.
 - Despair in the hearts and minds of the people of Judah,
 - and they turn away from God
 - and then they too are destroyed by Babylon.

Habakkuk = embrace

1:1-4 - prayer lament - wait a minute, you're letting Babylon the Chaldeans come and wipe out the kingdom of Judah because the kingdom of Judah is wicked, well guess what Lord, Babylon is way more wicked than Judah, so why are you letting these very bad people wipe out your mostly bad kingdom of Judah.

1:5-11 - God responds - I know. I haven't inspired them, I'm not making them do this, their violence, their wickedness, it's of their own making, but I'm allowing it.

1:12-17 2nd prayer lament - So that brings in the question - why would you allow this more wicked nation to do this.

2 God responds - look, you've got to trust me on this, there's a larger plan here.

Romans 1:17 - Paul quotes this here - and much of his entire epistle is based on this principle

v2-3 - but the just shall live by "his" faith

- How often in your life has God asked you to trust him on something when it didn't make sense, you didn't like the way it turned out or that it was going to possibly turn out. That is all wrapped up in the idea of faith. Faith is a very complex word and in the scriptures it's tied up into covenantal language about loyalty and faithfulness and belief in God.

3 Final prayer - 3:17, **18**, 19 -

Acronym - UIA

- U-nderstand
 - Context
 - Who's writing, who is their audience, how does it fit into the bigger picture
 - Content
 - Actual words - what are they saying, what do they mean, what underlies the words in their original language
- I-dentify (+ understand)
 - Principles
 - Stated - something like, "wickedness never was happiness"
 - Implied
 - Doctrines
- A-pply
 - To our own lives and settings today